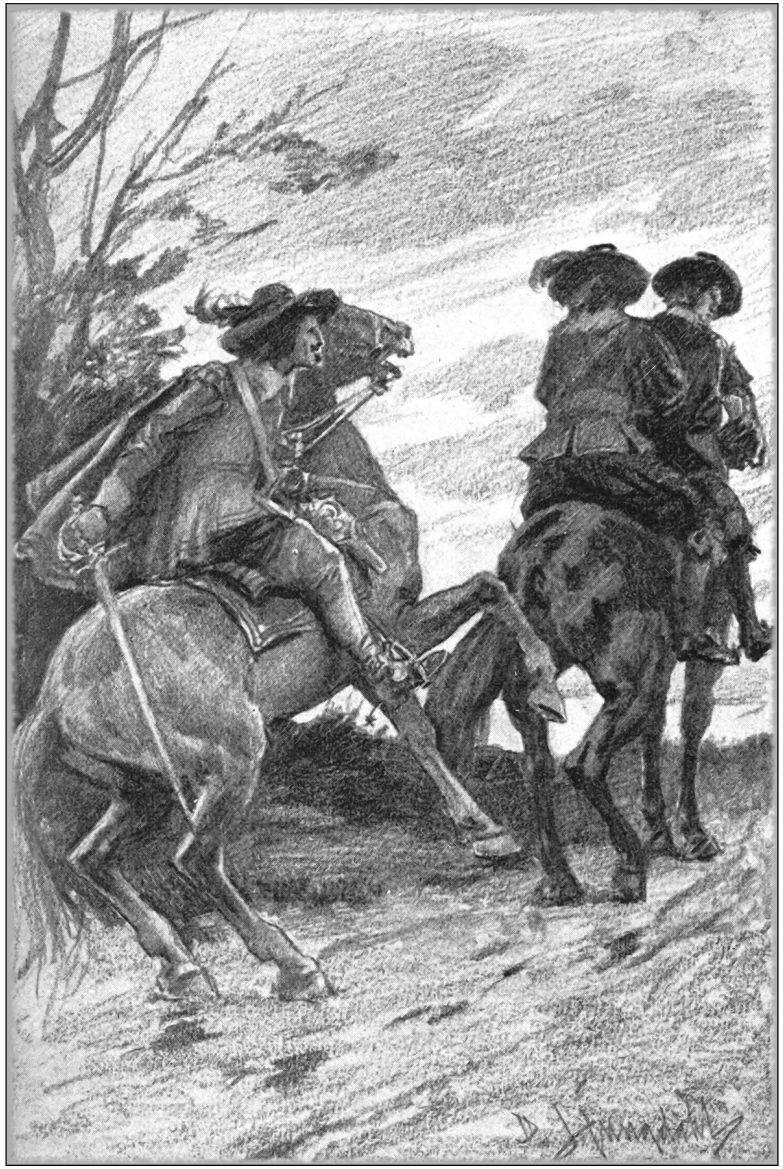

D'Artagnan saw two human forms on Planchet's horse

''Tis then the devil that pursues!' he cried; drawing his sword and preparing to attack the new foe.

'No, no, dear D'Artagnan,' said the figure, ''tis not the devil, 'tis Aramis; gallop fast, Planchet, and when you come to the end of the village turn swiftly to the left.'

And Planchet, with Aramis behind him, set off at full gallop, followed by D'Artagnan, who began to think he was in the merry maze of some fantastic dream.

'I am waiting for no one,' replied D'Artagnan, who was beginning to be angry. 'I propose to defend no one but myself, and I shall defend myself vigorously, I give you warning.'

'Very well,' said the voice; 'go away from here and leave the place to us.'

'Go away from here!' said D'Artagnan, whose purposes were in conflict with that order, 'that is not so easy, since I am on the point of falling, and my horse, too, through fatigue; unless, indeed, you are disposed to offer me a supper and a bed in the neighbourhood.'

'Rascal!'

'Eh! monsieur!' said D'Artagnan, 'I beg you will have a care what you say; for if you utter another word like that, be you marquis, duke, prince or king, I will thrust it down your throat! do you hear?'

'Well, well,' rejoined the leader, 'there's no doubt 'tis a Gascon who is speaking, and therefore not the man we are looking for. Our blow has failed for to-night; let us withdraw. We shall meet again, Master d'Artagnan,' continued the leader, raising his voice.

'Yes, but never with the same advantages,' said D'Artagnan, in a tone of raillery; 'for when you meet me again you will perhaps be alone and there will be daylight.'

'Very good, very good,' said the voice. '*En route*, gentlemen.'

And the troop, grumbling angrily, disappeared in the darkness and took the road to Paris. D'Artagnan and Planchet remained for some moments still on the defensive; then, as the noise of the horsemen became more and more distant, they sheathed their swords.

'Thou seest, simpleton,' said D'Artagnan to his servant, 'that they wished no harm to us.'

'But to whom, then?'

'I'faith! I neither know nor care. What I do care for now, is to make my way into the Jesuits' convent; so to horse and let us knock at their door. Happen what will, the devil take them, they can't eat us.'

And he mounted his horse. Planchet had just done the same when an unexpected weight fell upon the back of the horse, which sank down.

'Hey! your honour!' cried Planchet, 'I've a man behind me.'

D'Artagnan turned around and plainly saw two human forms on Planchet's horse.

'Halloo, gentlemen!' he called out in his Gascon accent, 'what do you want? what do you demand?'

'That thou shalt soon know,' shouted a chorus of horsemen.

'Stop, stop!' cried he whom they had addressed as 'my lord;' ''tis not his voice.'

'Ah! just so, gentlemen! pray, do people get into a passion at random at Noisy? Take care, for I warn you that the first man that comes within the length of my sword—and my sword is long—I rip him up.'

The chieftain of the party drew near.

'What are you doing here?' he asked in a lofty tone, as that of one accustomed to command.

'And you—what are *you* doing here?' replied D'Artagnan.

'Be civil, or I shall beat you; for although one may not choose to proclaim oneself, one insists on respect suitable to one's rank.'

'You don't choose to discover yourself, because you are the leader of an ambuscade,' returned D'Artagnan; 'but with regard to myself, who am travelling quietly with my own servant, I have not the same reasons as you have to conceal my name.'

'Enough! enough! what is your name?'

'I shall tell you my name in order that you may know where to find me, my lord, or my prince, as it may suit you best to be called,' said our Gascon, who did not choose to seem to yield to a threat. 'Do you know Monsieur d'Artagnan?'

'Lieutenant in the king's musketeers?' said the voice; 'you are Monsieur d'Artagnan?'

'I am.'

'Then you came here to defend him?'

'Him? whom?'

'The man we are seeking.'

'It seems,' said D'Artagnan, 'that whilst I thought I was coming to Noisy I have entered, without suspecting it, into the kingdom of mysteries.'

'Come,' replied the same lofty tone, 'answer! Are you waiting for him underneath these windows? Did you come to Noisy to defend him?'

Chapter IX

The Abbé D'Herblay

AT the extremity of the village Planchet turned to the left in obedience to the orders of Aramis, and stopped underneath the window which had light in it. Aramis alighted and clapped his hands three times. Immediately the window was opened and a ladder of rope was let down from it.

'My friend,' said Aramis, 'if you like to ascend I shall be delighted to receive you.'

'Ah,' said D'Artagnan, 'is that the way you return to your apartment?'

'After nine at night, *pardieu!*' said Aramis, 'the rule of the convent is very severe.'

'Pardon me, my dear friend,' said D'Artagnan, 'I think you said "*pardieu!*"'

'Do you think so?' said Aramis, smiling; 'it is possible. You have no idea, my dear fellow, how one acquires bad habits in these cursed convents, or what evil ways all these men of the church have, with whom I am obliged to live. But will you not go up?'

'Pass on before me, I beg of you.'

'As the late cardinal used to say to the late king, "only to show you the way, sire."' And Aramis ascended the ladder quickly and reached the window in an instant.

D'Artagnan followed, but less nimbly, showing plainly that this mode of ascent was not one to which he was accustomed.

'I beg your pardon,' said Aramis, noticing his awkwardness; 'if I had known that I was to have the honour of your visit I should have procured the gardener's ladder; but for me alone this is good enough.'

'Sir,' said Planchet when he saw D'Artagnan on the summit of the ladder, 'this way is easy for Monsieur Aramis and even for you; in case of necessity I might also climb up, but my two horses cannot mount the ladder.'

'Take them to yonder shed, my friend,' said Aramis, pointing to a low building on the plain; 'there you will find hay and straw for them; then come back here and clap your hands three times, and we will give you wine and food. Marry, forsooth, people don't die of hunger here.'

And Aramis, drawing in the ladder, closed the window. D'Artagnan then looked around attentively.

Never was there an apartment at the same time more warlike and more elegant. At each corner were arranged trophies, presenting to view swords of all sorts, and on the walls hung four great pictures representing in their ordinary military costume the Cardinal de Lorraine, the Cardinal de Richelieu, the Cardinal de la Valette, and the Archbishop of Bordeaux. Exteriorly, nothing in the room showed that it was the habitation of an abbé. The hangings were of damask, the carpets from Alençon, and the bed, especially, had more the look of a fine lady's couch, with its trimmings of fine lace and its embroidered counterpane, than that of a man who had made a vow that he would endeavour to gain Heaven by fasting and mortification.

'You are examining my den,' said Aramis. 'Ah, my dear fellow, excuse me; I am lodged like a Chartreux. But what are you looking for?'

'I am looking for the person who let down the ladder. I see no one and yet the ladder didn't come down of itself.'

'No, it is Bazin.'

'Ah! ah!' said D'Artagnan.

'But,' continued Aramis, 'Bazin is a well trained servant, and seeing that I was not alone he discreetly retired. Sit down, my dear friend, and let us talk.' And Aramis pushed forward a large easy-chair, in which D'Artagnan stretched himself out.

'In the first place, you will sup with me, will you not?' asked Aramis.

'Yes, if you really wish it,' said D'Artagnan, 'and even with great pleasure, I confess; the journey has given me a devil of an appetite.'

'Ah, my poor friend!' said Aramis, 'you will find meagre fare; you were not expected.'

'Am I then threatened with the omelet of Crèvecœur?'

and there a dog barked behind a door or an affrighted cat fled precipitately from the midst of the pavement to take refuge behind a pile of faggots, from which retreat her eyes would shine like peridores. These were the only living creatures that seemed to inhabit the village.

Toward the middle of the town, commanding the principal open space, rose a dark mass, separated from the rest of the world by two lanes and overshadowed in the front by enormous lime-trees. D'Artagnan looked attentively at the building.

'This,' he said to Planchet, 'must be the archbishop's château, the abode of the fair Madame de Longueville; but the convent, where is that?'

'The convent, your honour, is at the other end of the village; I know it well.'

'Well, then, Planchet, gallop up to it whilst I tighten my horse's girth, and come back and tell me if there is a light in any of the Jesuits' windows.'

In about five minutes Planchet returned.

'Sir,' he said, 'there is one window of the convent lighted up.'

'Hem! If I were a "Frondeur,"' said D'Artagnan, 'I should knock here and should be sure of a good supper. If I were a monk I should knock yonder and should have a good supper there, too; whereas, 'tis very possible that between the castle and the convent we shall sleep on hard beds, dying with hunger and thirst.'

'Yes,' added Planchet, 'like the famous ass of Buridan. Shall I knock?'

'Hush!' replied D'Artagnan; 'the light no longer burns in yonder window.'

'Do you hear nothing?' whispered Planchet.

'What is that noise?'

There came a sound like a whirlwind, at the same time two troops of horsemen, each composed of ten men, sallied forth from each of the lanes which encompassed the house and surrounded D'Artagnan and Planchet.

'Heyday!' cried D'Artagnan, drawing his sword and taking refuge behind his horse; 'are you not mistaken? is it really for us that you mean your attack?'

'Here he is! we have him!' cried the horsemen, rushing on D'Artagnan with naked swords.

'Don't let him escape!' said a loud voice.

'No, my lord; be assured we shall not.'

D'Artagnan thought it was now time for him to join in the conversation.

'Well, what matters all that to us?' said D'Artagnan. 'This is one of those attempts that happen every day.'

'Are you sure that we are not its objects?'

'We? Why?'

'Just remember what they said. "I have seen his servant," said one, and that applies very well to me.'

'Well?'

'"He must certainly be at Noisy, or be coming there this evening," said the other; and that applies very well to you.'

'What else?'

'Then the prince said: "Take notice that in all probability he will be disguised as a cavalier;" which seems to me to leave no room for doubt, since you are dressed as a cavalier and not as an officer of musketeers. Now then, what do you say to that?'

'Alas! my dear Planchet,' said D'Artagnan, sighing, 'we are unfortunately no longer in those times in which princes would care to assassinate me. Those were good old days; never fear—these people owe us no grudge.'

'Is your honour *sure?*'

'I can answer for it they do not.'

'Well, we won't speak of it any more, then;' and Planchet took his place in D'Artagnan's suite with that sublime confidence he had always had in his master, which even fifteen years of separation had not destroyed.

They had travelled onward about half a mile when Planchet came close up to D'Artagnan.

'Stop, sir, look yonder,' he whispered; 'don't you see in the darkness something pass by, like shadows? I fancy I hear horses' feet.'

'Impossible!' returned D'Artagnan. 'The ground is soaking wet; yet I fancy, as thou sayest, that I see something.'

At this moment the neighing of a horse struck his ear, coming through darkness and space.

'There are men somewhere about, but that's of no consequence to us,' said D'Artagnan; 'let us ride onward.'

At about half-past eight o'clock they reached the first houses in Noisy; every one was in bed and not a light was to be seen in the village. The obscurity was broken only now and then by the still darker lines of the roofs of houses. Here

'Oh, let us hope,' said Aramis, 'that with the help of God and of Bazin we shall find something better than that in the larder of the worthy Jesuit fathers. Bazin, my friend, come here.'

The door opened and Bazin entered; on perceiving the musketeer he uttered an exclamation that was almost a cry of despair.

'My dear Bazin,' said D'Artagnan, 'I am delighted to see with what wonderful composure you can tell a lie even in church!'

'Sir,' replied Bazin, 'I have been taught by the good Jesuit fathers that it is permitted to tell a falsehood when it is told in a good cause.'

'So far well,' said Aramis; 'we are dying of hunger. Serve us up the best supper you can, and especially give us some good wine.'

Bazin bowed low, sighed, and left the room.

'Now we are alone, dear Aramis,' said D'Artagnan, 'tell me how the devil you managed to alight upon the back of Planchet's horse.'

'I'faith!' answered Aramis, 'as you see, from Heaven.'

'From Heaven,' replied D'Artagnan, shaking his head; 'you have no more the appearance of coming from thence than you have of going there.'

'My friend,' said Aramis, with a look of imbecility on his face which D'Artagnan had never observed whilst he was in the musketeers, 'if I did not come from Heaven, at least I was leaving Paradise, which is almost the same.'

'Here, then, is a puzzle for the learned,' observed D'Artagnan, 'until now they have never been able to agree as to the situation of Paradise; some place it on Mount Ararat, others between the rivers Tigris and Euphrates; it seems that they have been looking very far away for it, while it was actually very near. Paradise is at Noisy le Sec, upon the site of the archbishop's château. People do not go out from it by the door, but by the window; one doesn't descend here by the marble steps of a peristyle, but by the branches of a lime-tree; and the angel with a flaming sword who guards this elysium seems to have changed his celestial name of Gabriel into that of the more terrestrial one of the Prince de Marsillac.'

Aramis burst into a fit of laughter.

'You were always a merry companion, my dear D'Artagnan,' he said, 'and your witty Gascon fancy has not deserted you. Yes, there is something in what you say; nevertheless, do not believe that it is Madame de Longueville with whom I am in love.'

'A plague on't! I shall not do so. After having been so long in love with Madame de Chevreuse, you would hardly lay your heart at the feet of her mortal enemy!'

'Yes,' replied Aramis, with an absent air; 'yes, that poor duchess! I once loved her much, and to do her justice, she was very useful to us. Eventually she was obliged to leave France. He was a relentless enemy, that damned cardinal,' continued Aramis, glancing at the portrait of the old minister. 'He had even given orders to arrest her and would have cut off her head had she not escaped with her waiting-maid—poor Kitty! I have heard that she met with a strange adventure in I don't know what village, with I don't know what curé, of whom she asked hospitality and who, having but one chamber, and taking her for a cavalier, offered to share it with her. For she had a wonderful way of dressing as a man, that dear Marie; I know only one other woman who can do it as well. So they made this song about her: "*Laboissiere, dis moi*." You know it, don't you?'

'No, sing it, please.'

Aramis immediately complied, and sang the song in a very lively manner.

'Bravo!' cried D'Artagnan, 'you sing charmingly, dear Aramis. I do not perceive that singing masses has spoiled your voice.'

'My dear D'Artagnan,' replied Aramis, 'you understand, when I was a musketeer I mounted guard as seldom as I could; now when I am an abbé I say as few masses as I can. But to return to our duchess.'

'Which—the Duchess de Chevreuse or the Duchess de Longueville?'

'Have I not already told you that there is nothing between me and the Duchess de Longueville? Little flirtations, perhaps, and that's all. No, I spoke of the Duchess de Chevreuse; did you see her after her return from Brussels, after the king's death?'

'Yes, she is still beautiful.'

'Yes,' said Aramis, 'I saw her also at that time. I gave her good advice, by which she did not profit. I ventured to tell her that Mazarin was the lover of Anne of Austria. She wouldn't believe me, saying that she knew Anne of Austria, who was too proud to love such a worthless coxcomb. After that she plunged into the cabal headed by the Duke of Beaufort; and the "coxcomb" arrested De Beaufort and banished Madame de Chevreuse.'

'I will lay a wager, your honour, that you and I are thinking of the same thing.'

'I doubt it, Planchet,' replied D'Artagnan, 'but what are you thinking of?'

'I am thinking, sir, of those desperate looking men who were drinking in the inn where we rested.'

'Always cautious, Planchet.'

''Tis instinct, your honour.'

'Well, what does your instinct tell you now?'

'Sir, my instinct told me that those people were assembled there for some bad purpose; and I was reflecting on what my instinct had told me, in the darkest corner of the stable, when a man wrapped in a cloak and followed by two other men, came in.'

'Ah ah!' said D'Artagnan, Planchet's recital agreeing with his own observations. 'Well?'

'One of these two men said, "He must certainly be at Noisy, or be coming there this evening, for I have seen his servant."

"Art thou sure?" said the man in the cloak.

"Yes, my prince."'

'My prince!' interrupted D'Artagnan.

'Yes, "my prince;" but listen. "If he is here"—this is what the other man said—"let's see decidedly what to do with him."

"What to do with him?" answered the prince.

"Yes, he's not a man to allow himself to be taken anyhow; he'll defend himself."

"Well, we must try to take him alive. Have you cords to bind him with and a gag to stop his mouth?"

"We have."

"Remember that he will most likely be disguised as a horseman."

"Yes, yes, my lord; don't be uneasy."

"Besides, I shall be there."

"You will assure us that justice— "

"Yes, yes! I answer for all that," the prince said.

"Well, then, we'll do our best." Having said that, they went out of the stable.'

appeared at the door, but seeing a stranger he beckoned to his companions, and two men who were drinking in the inn went out to speak to him.

D'Artagnan, on his side, went up to the landlady, praised her wine—which was a horrible production from the country of Montreuil—and heard from her that there were only two houses of importance in the village; one of these belonged to the Archbishop of Paris, and was at that time the abode of his niece the Duchess of Longueville; the other was a convent of Jesuits and was the property—a by no means unusual circumstance—of these worthy fathers.

At four o'clock D'Artagnan recommenced his journey. He proceeded slowly and in deep reverie. Planchet also was lost in thought, but the subject of their reflections was not the same.

One word which their landlady had pronounced had given a particular turn to D'Artagnan's deliberations; this was the name of Madame de Longueville.

That name was indeed one to inspire imagination and produce thought. Madame de Longueville was one of the highest ladies in the realm; she was also one of the greatest beauties at court. She had formerly been suspected of an intimacy of too tender a nature with Coligny, who, for her sake, had been killed in a duel, in the Place Royale, by the Duc de Guise. She was now connected by bonds of a political nature with the Prince de Marsillac, the eldest son of the old Duc de Rochefoucauld, whom she was trying to inspire with an enmity toward the Duc de Condé, her brother-in-law, whom she now hated mortally.

D'Artagnan thought of all these matters. He remembered how at the Louvre he had often seen, as she passed by him in the full radiance of her dazzling charms, the beautiful Madame de Longueville. He thought of Aramis, who, without possessing any greater advantages than himself, had formerly been the lover of Madame de Chevreuse, who had been to a former court what Madame de Longueville was in that day; and he wondered how it was that there should be in the world people who succeed in every wish, some in ambition, others in love, whilst others, either from chance, or from ill-luck, or from some natural defect or impediment, remain half-way upon the road toward fulfilment of their hopes and expectations.

He was confessing to himself that he belonged to the latter unhappy class, when Planchet approached and said:

'You know,' resumed D'Artagnan, 'that she has had leave to return to France?'

'Yes she is come back and is going to commit some fresh folly or another.'

'Oh, but this time perhaps she will follow your advice.'

'Oh, this time,' returned Aramis, 'I haven't seen her; she is much changed.'

'In that respect unlike you, my dear Aramis, for you are still the same; you have still your beautiful dark hair, still your elegant figure, still your feminine hands, which are admirably suited to a prelate.'

'Yes,' replied Aramis, 'I am extremely careful of my appearance. Do you know that I am growing old? I am nearly thirty-seven.'

'Mind, Aramis'—D'Artagnan smiled as he spoke—'since we are together again, let us agree on one point: what age shall we be in future?'

'How?'

'Formerly I was your junior by two or three years, and if I am not mistaken I am turned forty years old.'

'Indeed! Then 'tis I who am mistaken, for you have always been a good chronologist. By your reckoning I must be forty-three at least. The devil I am! Don't let it out at the Hotel Rambouillet; it would ruin me,' replied the abbé.

'Don't be afraid,' said D'Artagnan. 'I never go there.'

'Why, what in the world,' cried Aramis, 'is that animal Bazin doing? Bazin! Hurry up there, you rascal; we are mad with hunger and thirst!'

Bazin entered at that moment carrying a bottle in each hand.

'At last,' said Aramis, 'we are ready, are we?'

'Yes, monsieur, quite ready,' said Bazin; 'but it took me some time to bring up all the— '

'Because you always think you have on your shoulders your beadle's robe, and spend all your time reading your breviary. But I give you warning that if in polishing your chapel utensils you forget how to brighten up my sword, I will make a great fire of your blessed images and will see that you are roasted on it.'

Bazin, scandalised, made a sign of the cross with the bottle in his hand. D'Artagnan, more surprised than ever at the tone and manners of the Abbé d'Herblay, which contrasted so strongly with those of the Musketeer Aramis, remained staring with wide-open eyes at the face of his friend.

Bazin quickly covered the table with a damask cloth and arranged upon it so many things, gilded, perfumed, appetizing, that D'Artagnan was quite overcome.

'But you expected some one then?' asked the officer.

'Oh,' said Aramis, 'I always try to be prepared; and then I knew you were seeking me.'

'From whom?'

'From Master Bazin, to be sure; he took you for the devil, my dear fellow, and hastened to warn me of the danger that threatened my soul if I should meet again a companion so wicked as an officer of musketeers.'

'Oh, monsieur!' said Bazin, clasping his hands supplicatingly.

'Come, no hypocrisy! you know that I don't like it. You will do much better to open the window and let down some bread, a chicken and a bottle of wine to your friend Planchet, who has been this last hour killing himself clapping his hands.'

Planchet, in fact, had bedded and fed his horses, and then coming back under the window had repeated two or three times the signal agreed upon.

Bazin obeyed, fastened to the end of a cord the three articles designated and let them down to Planchet, who then went satisfied to his shed.

'Now to supper,' said Aramis.

The two friends sat down and Aramis began to cut up fowls, partridges and hams with admirable skill.

'The deuce!' cried D'Artagnan; 'do you live in this way always?'

'Yes, pretty well. The coadjutor has given me dispensations from fasting on the *jours maigres*, on account of my health; then I have engaged as my cook the cook who lived with Lafollone—you know the man I mean?—the friend of the cardinal, and the famous epicure whose grace after dinner used to be, "Good Lord, do me the favour to cause me to digest what I have eaten."'

'Nevertheless he died of indigestion, in spite of his grace,' said D'Artagnan.

'What can you expect?' replied Aramis, in a tone of resignation. 'Every man that's born must fulfil his destiny.'

'If it be not an indelicate question,' resumed D'Artagnan, 'have you grown rich?'

'Oh, Heaven! no. I make about twelve thousand francs a year, without counting a little benefice of a thousand crowns the prince gave me.'

Chapter VIII

D'Artagnan, Going to a Distance to Discover Aramis

On entering the hotel D'Artagnan saw a man sitting in a corner by the fire. It was Planchet, but so completely transformed, thanks to the old clothes that the departing husband had left behind, that D'Artagnan himself could hardly recognise him. Madeleine introduced him in presence of all the servants. Planchet addressed the officer with a fine Flemish phrase; the officer replied in words that belonged to no language at all, and the bargain was concluded; Madeleine's brother entered D'Artagnan's service.

The plan adopted by D'Artagnan was soon perfected. He resolved not to reach Noisy in the day, for fear of being recognised; he had therefore plenty of time before him, for Noisy is only three or four leagues from Paris, on the road to Meaux.

He began his day by breakfasting substantially—a bad beginning when one wants to employ the head, but an excellent precaution when one wants to work the body; and about two o'clock he had his two horses saddled, and followed by Planchet he quitted Paris by the Barrière de la Villete. A most active search was still prosecuted in the house near the Hotel de la Chevrette for the discovery of Planchet.

At about a league and a half from the city, D'Artagnan, finding that in his impatience he had set out too soon, stopped to give the horses breathing time. The inn was full of disreputable looking people, who seemed as if they were on the point of commencing some nightly expedition. A man, wrapped in a cloak,

'I think so, truly; my nurse lives there.'

'Is there a convent at Noisy?'

'Isn't there a great and grand one—the convent of Jesuits?'

'What is thy name?'

'Friquet.'

D'Artagnan wrote the child's name in his tablets.

'Please, sir,' said the boy, 'do you think I can gain any more half-pistoles in any way?'

'Perhaps,' replied D'Artagnan.

And having got out all he wanted, he paid for the hypocras, which he did not drink, and went quickly back to the Rue Tiquetonne.

'And how do you make your twelve thousand francs? By your poems?'

'No, I have given up poetry, except now and then to write a drinking song, some gay sonnet or some innocent epigram; I compose sermons, my friend.'

'What! sermons? Do you preach them?'

'No; I sell them to those of my cloth who wish to become great orators.'

'Ah, indeed! and you have not been tempted by the hopes of reputation yourself?'

'I should, my dear D'Artagnan, have been so, but nature said "No." When I am in the pulpit, if by chance a pretty woman looks at me, I look at her again: if she smiles, I smile too. Then I speak at random; instead of preaching about the torments of hell I talk of the joys of Paradise. An event took place in the Church of St Louis au Marais. A gentleman laughed in my face. I stopped short to tell him that he was a fool; the congregation went out to get stones to stone me with, but whilst they were away I found means to conciliate the priests who were present, so that my foe was pelted instead of me. 'Tis true that he came the next morning to my house, thinking that he had to do with an abbé—like all other abbés.'

'And what was the end of the affair?'

'We met in the Place Royale—Egad! you know about it.'

'Was I not your second?' cried D'Artagnan.

'You were; you know how I settled the matter.'

'Did he die?'

'I don't know. But, at all events, I gave him absolution *in articulo mortis*. 'Tis enough to kill the body, without killing the soul.'

Bazin made a despairing sign which meant that while perhaps he approved the moral he altogether disapproved the tone in which it was uttered.

'Bazin, my friend,' said Aramis, 'you don't seem to be aware that I can see you in that mirror, and you forget that once for all I have forbidden all signs of approbation or disapprobation. You will do me the favour to bring us some Spanish wine and then to withdraw. Besides, my friend D'Artagnan has something to say to me privately, have you not, D'Artagnan?'

D'Artagnan nodded his head and Bazin retired, after placing on the table the Spanish wine.

The two friends, left alone, remained silent, face to face. Aramis seemed to await a comfortable digestion; D'Artagnan, to be preparing his exordium.

Each of them, when the other was not looking, hazarded a sly glance. It was Aramis who broke the silence.

'What are you thinking of, D'Artagnan?' he began.

'I was thinking, my dear old friend, that when you were a musketeer you turned your thoughts incessantly to the church, and now that you are an abbé you are perpetually longing to be once more a musketeer.'

''Tis true; man, as you know,' said Aramis, 'is a strange animal, made up of contradictions. Since I became an abbé I dream of nothing but battles.'

'That is apparent in your surroundings; you have rapiers here of every form and to suit the most exacting taste. Do you still fence well?'

'I—I fence as well as you did in the old time—better still, perhaps; I do nothing else all day.'

'And with whom?'

'With an excellent master-at-arms that we have here.'

'What! here?'

'Yes, here, in this convent, my dear fellow. There is everything in a Jesuit convent.'

'Then you would have killed Monsieur de Marsillac if he had come alone to attack you, instead of at the head of twenty men?'

'Undoubtedly,' said Aramis, 'and even at the head of his twenty men, if I could have drawn without being recognised.'

'God pardon me!' said D'Artagnan to himself, 'I believe he has become more Gascon than I am!' Then aloud: 'Well, my dear Aramis, do you ask me why I came to seek you?'

'No, I have not asked you that,' said Aramis, with his subtle manner; 'but I have expected you to tell me.'

'Well, I sought you for the single purpose of offering you a chance to kill Monsieur de Marsillac whenever you please, prince though he is.'

'Hold on! wait!' said Aramis; 'that is an idea!'

'Of which I invite you to take advantage, my friend. Let us see; with your thousand crowns from the abbey and the twelve thousand francs you make by selling sermons, are you rich? Answer frankly.'

'I? I am as poor as Job, and were you to search my pockets and my boxes I don't believe you would find a hundred pistoles.'

'Half a pistole if you can find out,' said D'Artagnan.

'For me?' cried the boy, his eyes sparkling with joy, 'if I can find out where Bazin is going? That is not difficult. You are not joking, are you?'

'No, on the honour of an officer; there is the half-pistole;' and he showed him the seductive coin, but did not give it him.

'I shall ask him.'

'Just the very way not to know. Wait till he is set out and then, marry, come up, ask, and find out. The half-pistole is ready,' and he put it back again into his pocket.

'I understand,' said the child, with that jeering smile which marks especially the 'gamin de Paris.'

'Well, we must wait.'

They had not long to wait. Five minutes afterward Bazin set off on a full trot, urging on his horse by the blows of a parapluie, which he was in the habit of using instead of a riding whip.

Scarcely had he turned the corner of the Rue de la Juiverie when the boy rushed after him like a bloodhound on full scent.

Before ten minutes had elapsed the child returned.

'Well!' said D'Artagnan.

'Well!' answered the boy, 'the thing is done.'

'Where is he gone?'

'The half-pistole is for me?'

'Doubtless, answer me.'

'I want to see it. Give it me, that I may see it is not false.'

'There it is.'

The child put the piece of money into his pocket.

'And now, where is he gone?' inquired D'Artagnan.

'He is gone to Noisy.'

'How dost thou know?'

'Ah, faith! there was no great cunning necessary. I knew the horse he rode; it belonged to the butcher, who lets it out now and then to M. Bazin. Now I thought that the butcher would not let his horse out like that without knowing where it was going. And he answered "that Monsieur Bazin went to Noisy." 'Tis his custom. He goes two or three times a week.'

'Dost thou know Noisy well?'